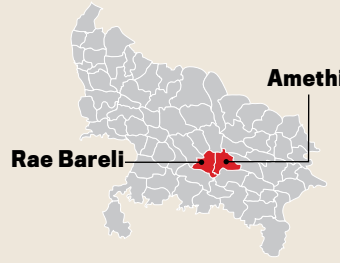
and pro-Congress media corps—which had been taking the anticipatory drum beats to a crescendo—found only partial fulfilment. On May 3, the last day for nominations, Rahul filed his papers from Rae Bareli. Priyanka would not be in the field—except as a star campaigner.

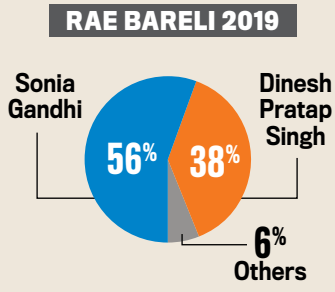
The news met with mixed reactions. The BJP mocked Rahul, saying he was wary of facing Smriti again, in line with the taunt Modi had lobbed: "*Bhaago mat...lado* (don't run, fight)". Congress insiders, though, call it a well-thought-out strategy. Rae Bareli has been a Family bastion since Feroze Gandhi won it for the first Lok Sabha in 1952, with the status of a prime ministerial constituency during Indira Gandhi's 1967-77 term in office. And Sonia has held it for 20 years now—unaffected even by the Modi wave in 2014 and 2019. It, therefore, carries a certain cachet. A few months ago, Sonia had written a thank-you letter to her constituents saying the Gandhis would continue to serve them even though she was moving to the Upper House.



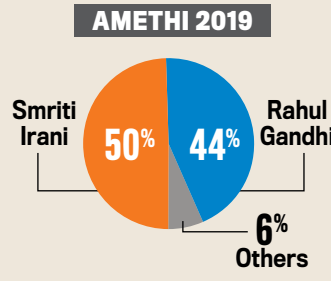
THE FAMILY LAND BANK

Rahul decides to skip Amethi. Will the other Gandhi fiefdom hold?





▲ Lok Sabha ▼



BJP Cong. Others

Vote share figures have been rounded off



THE WAR ZONE
(Left) Priyanka, Rahul and Sonia Gandhi en route to Rae Bareli, May 3; (above) Amethi Congress candidate K.L. Sharma

Rahul was apparently reluctant to step in, saying he could not leave his adopted seat—Wayanad in Kerala—if he won both. It was Sonia, sources say, who impressed upon him that he had to bow to the cadre's wishes. The party did not want to send the message that "the North didn't matter" to Rahul as he had a safe seat in the South. Amethi got the thumbs down as it would have descended into a "prestige battle", tying down the party's main campaigner and its own scarce resources. Smriti, denied the benefit of a high-profile contest, now has unassuming Family loyalist Kishori Lal Sharma as her rival. Says a senior leader, "We did not want another Rahul vs Smriti narrative in the media. Rahul is a national leader, there's no need for him to go down to their level. What we are saying is, 'Our Kishori is enough to take on Irani'." Priyanka, her own candidacy deferred to a putative bypoll in the future, will do the heavy lifting on the campaign trail in both seats.

AMETHI APPARENTLY GOT THE THUMBS DOWN AS IT WOULD HAVE TURNED INTO A "PRESTIGE BATTLE", TYING DOWN RAHUL, THE PARTY'S MAIN CAMPAIGNER

The BJP has fielded local Dinesh Pratap Singh again from Rae Bareli. A party-hopper and ex-Sonia campaign manager, he's no pushover, having halved her winning margin to 167,000-odd votes in 2019. What won't harm the Congress is the tie-up with the Samajwadi Party, which holds four of the five assembly seats under Rae Bareli. Kishori Lal is no stranger to Amethi either, having worked for the party here for over 40 years and been close to the Family since the days of Rajiv Gandhi. "I first came to Amethi in 1983. I know people in each and every block here," he tells INDIA TODAY. "The people will vote for me and the Gandhis. They are annoyed with Smriti here." The anti-incumbency dart may hit, but Sharma has barely three weeks to soothe locals for being abandoned by Rahul. ■